

Chapter 102-1 - Courtship

Her lips were soft and delicate under the lamplight, with a faint herbal fragrance detectable. Ning Fuyi's throat felt somewhat dry. She swallowed silently and turned her head to lean down.

The touch was sweet and soft, reminding Ning Fuyi of the malt candy she had eaten as a child. Tasting the flavor, she couldn't help but go deeper, hearing soft murmurs emerge from between their lips as palms caressed her shoulders.

Actually, during all these days, the two of them had been very respectful toward each other. Their daily contact was mostly just companionship. Now that Su Mo had suddenly taken a step forward, it made Ning Fuyi's heart flutter without bounds.

Su Mo was too soft - not weak, but that kind of softness like willow catkins that could disappear in the wind at any moment. Ning Fuyi didn't dare expose even a hint of her own wildness to her.

Su Mo curled her toes, both panicked and afraid. She still very much disliked being in such close contact with people, trembling nervously all over. The hands resting on the woman's shoulders unconsciously applied more force, pinching until Ning Fuyi drew in a sharp breath and separated from her lips.

Both their breathing quickened slightly. Ning Fuyi looked down at Su Mo's tightly closed eyes, smiled, circled her waist with her left hand, and smoothed her disheveled hair with her right hand.

"Don't be afraid." Ning Fuyi said softly. She lowered her head again, this time only lightly touching. The lamplight's flowing radiance danced, and the sound of insects was deafening.

Her kisses were deep and shallow, slowly melting away the wariness before Su Mo's eyes. Her body was no longer tense, gradually softening, falling into Ning Fuyi's arms like water.

She had never experienced this kind of feeling before. Her arms momentarily lost strength, dropping to her own chest, only to be picked up by Ning Fuyi, who slowly grasped her from fingertips to palm.

When the kiss ended, tears misted her vision, making the lamplight much hazier. Su Mo was dazed for a long time before coming back to her senses. She covered her face and slid down from Ning Fuyi, gesturing without looking at her: "It's getting late. I'm going back to my room to sleep."

"Su Mo." Ning Fuyi leaned back against the chair, reaching out to catch her arm. "Stay with me tonight?"

Su Mo looked at the hand with well-proportioned flesh and bone that was holding her wrist, the sensation on her lips surging in her heart again.

She loved the woman's hands the most - white as jade bone, with well-proportioned sinews and flesh, as if someone had specially carved them.

The nails were lustrous and transparent, like ten petal-white flower petals attached to her fingertips, clean and neat.

"I just want you to keep me company a bit longer." Ning Fuyi rested her head against the chair back, looking up at her with pleading phoenix eyes.

Su Mo was soft-hearted, especially unable to resist any of her requests. Though she felt anxious, she still stopped and didn't move, watching the woman get up to tidy things.

The woman's bed was also very neat, with fluffy padding underneath, bamboo mats spread over the padding, and silk quilts laid on top of the mats. It was wide on both sides, enough for two people to turn over.

After both had finished washing, they changed into undergarments and lay down. Ning Fuyi was afraid of the cool night wind, so she slept on the outer side. She raised her hand to extinguish the lamp and lay down properly.

Su Mo should have also lain down properly. They only had their arms touching, which was somewhat sweltering in the summer night, but even though they had sweat on their bodies, neither moved away.

The scents of both mingled in the air above the bed, finally condensing into a unique fragrance that made them both somewhat dizzy.

Ning Fuyi forced her eyes closed, but her mind instantly accommodated a hundred rivers¹, able to hear even the barking of dogs from who knows how far away.

Maybe I should just cast a sleep spell, Ning Fuyi thought.

Su Mo obviously hadn't fallen asleep either. Her whole body was tense like a wooden carving, hands crossed over her chest, rising and falling with her breathing.

Ning Fuyi wanted to remind her that sleeping like this could easily cause nightmares, but Su Mo couldn't hear. She could only reach out to move her hands to her lower abdomen. The moment she touched that wrist, Su Mo's entire body trembled.

After realizing that Ning Fuyi was only correcting her posture, Su Mo became so embarrassed that her whole body heated up. She moved toward the wall, pressing against the cool wall until she felt the temperature gradually dissipate.

Ning Fuyi exhaled softly. Just as she was about to cast a spell to make herself fall asleep, she felt Su Mo suddenly touch her arm. Her heartstrings immediately trembled, and she turned over planning to embrace her, but then heard Su Mo speak.

"I need to... use the privy..." Su Mo said with a red face.

"Oh, oh..." Ning Fuyi quickly turned over and got down, making room for her, watching Su Mo's slender figure escape into the night.

Ning Fuyi was somewhat amused. She propped herself up to sit, bending her knees against the bed post, waiting for Su Mo to return.

After who knows how long, the door finally opened again. Su Mo, covered with dew, stepped into the scattered moonlight, then turned to shut the moonlight out behind the door.

Accompanied by the rustling sound of clothing, Su Mo climbed back onto the bed. Ning Fuyi suddenly reached out to tug her sleeve, and Su Mo offered no resistance, falling against her shoulder.

She let out several light laughs.

"What, are you, laughing at?" Ning Fuyi felt like she was sitting on pins and needles from her laughter, gesturing in the dim room.

"Laughing at you, being silly." Su Mo said.

Hearing this, Ning Fuyi reached out to tickle the soft flesh at her waist. Su Mo struggled silently in her arms, and they played until the bed creaked loudly. Soon they were both sweating.

Su Mo originally wanted to tickle Ning Fuyi back, but no matter how she felt around, there were only clothes. Finally, she grabbed the clothing and pulled, causing both of them to fall onto the bed. The bedding beneath them was soft, like lying in the clouds.

Ning Fuyi smiled and relaxed her hands, falling into Su Mo's embrace, her head pillowed on her shoulder, holding her willow-like waist in her arms.

"Just now you said how nice it would be if it could always be like this. I think so too."

"When you wake up, whether or not you remember these days, you won't acknowledge them anyway." Ning Fuyi looked through the bed curtains toward the moon shadow outside the window, murmuring.

"Are you, saying, something?" Su Mo couldn't see her mouth movements, only felt the breath passing by, so she lowered her head to ask.

Ning Fuyi shook her head. She lifted Su Mo's arm, slipped out from under it, and took her hand to lie down properly again.

"Sleep." she said.

These thirty years had originally been peaceful throughout the realm, but this year was somewhat different. A long-absent drought gradually swept through the mortal world. The rain from the sky fell less and less, as if dark clouds no longer existed. Since the beginning of summer, they hadn't appeared for months.

Ning Fuyi was awakened by the heat before dawn. She wiped away her sweat and got up. Su Mo was still sleeping, her brows furrowed, her chest clothing soaked through with sweat, clinging tightly to her skin.

Ning Fuyi secretly cast a spell to cool the room. Seeing her expression become peaceful, she then lowered her head to place a kiss.

Then she dressed and went out. The moment she crossed the threshold, the air behind her suddenly transformed, already forming a barrier.

Jiuying² was already waiting for her outside the door, yawning. Her three thousand soft strands rose and fell with the wind, holding something in her hands, half-sitting on the low courtyard wall.

"Haven't rested for two days now. Being contracted with you is truly a hard life." Jiuying raised her hand to wipe away tears that seeped out from drowsiness, her embroidered shoes swaying in the morning breeze.

Ning Fuyi walked in front of her and flicked the head of the parrot sleeping soundly in her palm. The parrot immediately straightened its claws and fluttered.

"Scoundrel, scoundrel..."

"Didn't you teach it to say anything else?" Ning Fuyi covered her ears.

"I'm already doing well helping you raise it. It's so noisy it gives me a splitting headache." Jiuying raised her hand to pinch the bird's beak, silencing the indignant parrot.

Seeing it couldn't make noise, the parrot lay back down and began preening its feathers with its beak.

While preening, it accidentally pulled out a blue-yellow feather. The parrot held the feather in its beak for a moment, then suddenly fluttered its wings and flew up, inserting the feather into Jiuying's hair.

Jiuying frowned and removed the bird feather, throwing it into the wind with disgust: "What's it doing?"

Ning Fuyi shrugged to show she didn't understand. At this moment, Hannya³, who had been crouching outside the courtyard wall for a long time, suddenly said quietly: "Courtship."

"Court what?" Jiuying was stunned.

"Courtship." Hannya repeated, touching the black hair on her head. "This is the nature of us bird folk."

Footnotes:

1. **"Accommodated a hundred rivers" (容纳了百川)** - A poetic way of saying her mind was extremely active and alert, taking in all sorts of sounds and sensations.
2. **Jiuying (九婴)** - Ning Fuyi's contracted demon beast companion, a nine-headed creature that has taken human form.
3. **Hannya (寒鸦)** - Another of Ning Fuyi's demon servants, originally a crow spirit who understands bird behavior.